



THE LORD'S SUPPER

Distortions in the Ordinance

ALEX M KURUVILLA

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Author: Alex M Kuruvilla

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Mobile: +91 9633280848

Email: alexm.kuruvilla@gmail.com

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THE WORD OF LIFE MINISTRIES
ERNAKULAM

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Author's Preface

Our Lord Jesus Christ gave two ordinances for His church to follow. The first is 'Believer's Baptism'. This must be administered in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit (Matthew 28:18-19; Mark 16:15-16; Acts of the Apostles 2:38-41). The purpose of baptism is to unite a repentant sinner (the believer) with Christ in His death, burial, and resurrection (Romans 6:3-5). A repentant sinner should be baptized only once in his life.

The second is the Lord's Supper, which the church must observe on Sundays or whenever they assemble for corporate worship (Matthew 26:26-28; Mark 14:22-24; Luke 22:19-20; Acts 20:7; 1 Corinthians 10:15-17 & 11:23-30). The church must observe this ordinance continually until Jesus comes back. The purpose of this rite is to communicate (*koinonia*) the body and the blood of the risen Lord Jesus Christ (1 Corinthians 10:15-17) to the believer.

These are the only two ordinances Jesus gave to His church. But over time, some unbiblical and even anti-gospel customs have been added by others.

Regrettably, many Christian denominations have altered the ordinances of baptism and the Lord's Supper, shaping them to fit ecclesial convenience or cultural assimilation, often incorporating elements rooted in pagan traditions. Of the two, distortions concerning the Lord's Supper are particularly severe and widespread.

As early as AD 53-55, Paul rebuked the Corinthian church for their corrupted practice: "*When you come together, it is not the Lord's Supper that you eat*" (1 Cor. 11:20, ESV). This indicates that deviations had already emerged within the first generation of the church, despite apostolic oversight.

Tragically, the contemporary church remains fragmented in both doctrine and practice regarding this ordinance. The spectrum ranges from Transubstantiation, on one end, to Memorialism, on the other—positions that

both, in their extremes, fail to align with the holistic teaching of Scripture. This confusion stems from a lack of fidelity to Christ's commands regarding the Supper. Practicing these rites in distorted forms is not merely incorrect; it amounts to irreverence toward the Lord Himself.

Scripture warns that those who partake of the Supper in an unworthy manner bring judgment upon themselves—weakness, illness, and even death (1 Cor. 11:27-30). That such consequences are not widely observed today should not comfort us; rather, it suggests that what is being celebrated in many churches is no longer truly the Lord's Supper, thus rendering the question of participant worthiness moot.

A troubling inconsistency exists: many affirm the spiritual efficacy of baptism—our union with Christ in His death, burial, and resurrection (Rom. 6:3-11)—yet deny the *koinonia* (communion) of the body and blood of Christ as articulated in 1 Corinthians 10:15-17. This contradiction undermines the theological continuity between these two ordinances. The words “*Do this in remembrance*

of Me” are not merely a command to commemorate, but a call to participate—a sacramental act wherein remembrance is the means through which communion is realized.

Holy Communion is essential for the believer’s ongoing spiritual vitality and deepening union with Christ. It represents the highest expression of worship and fellowship with the risen Lord. The church in Laodicea lacked this fellowship; hence Christ’s words: *“Behold, I stand at the door and knock. If anyone hears my voice and opens the door, I will come in to him and eat with him, and he with me.”* (Rev. 3:20). The absence of true communion renders any ecclesial gathering spiritually impoverished. Therefore, we should not belittle the purpose of the Lord’s Supper by reducing it to a mere symbolic memorialism.

This booklet aims to clarify essential truths regarding the Lord’s Supper in a brief, question-and-answer format. Whatever light has been shed in these pages is the work of the Holy Spirit. I also gratefully acknowledge the influence of faithful theologians and expositors whose writings have been instrumental in my

understanding. Out of the depths of my heart, I thank God for them. May God alone be glorified in this humble work.

In the name of our Lord and Savior Jesus Christ,

Alex M Kuruvilla
Ernakulam - July 7, 2025

Introduction

The Lord's Supper stands at the center of Christian worship as one of the two ordinances instituted by Jesus Christ. Despite its centrality, it remains subject to significant theological misunderstanding and inconsistent practice. The following eight hypothetical pastoral conversations are designed to address common questions raised by thoughtful believers. Each response seeks to explain the biblical foundations, theological significance, and proper administration of the Lord's Supper with clarity, reverence, and fidelity to Scripture. The aim is to articulate a coherent and faithful understanding of the Supper as instituted by Christ and preserved by the early church.

Hypothetical Situation #1

The Question

Assume you are the pastor of a well-known church in the city. A young adult approaches you and asks:

“Pastor, I understand from Scripture that our Lord Jesus Christ instituted the Lord’s Supper while celebrating the Passover Feast—the final Passover of His earthly life. He could have instituted it on any other occasion. Why did He choose this particular moment? What is its significance?”

How would you respond?

The Answer

Our Lord Jesus Christ instituted the Lord’s Supper during the Passover Feast—the last He would celebrate before His suffering. This was not incidental, but deeply intentional. Consider

His words to His disciples: “*With fervent desire I have desired to eat this Passover with you before I suffer*” (Luke 22:15, NKJV). These words reveal a deliberate and eager anticipation. This moment was divinely appointed.

Why, then, did Jesus choose this final Passover to institute the Lord’s Supper?

Because through His death on the cross the following day—at the very time the Passover lambs were being sacrificed in the temple—Jesus, the true Lamb of God, brought the Passover to its ultimate fulfillment. As the Apostle Paul writes: “*For indeed Christ, our Passover, was sacrificed for us*” (1 Corinthians 5:7).

Thus, the Passover Feast of the Old Covenant finds its fulfillment in the death, burial, and resurrection of Jesus Christ. The Lord’s Supper, in turn, is not merely a ritual but a covenantal meal—a celebration of the New Covenant and a means of communion with Christ through remembrance. Every time we partake of it, we proclaim that the reality to which the Passover pointed has now been accomplished in Him:

“For as often as you eat this bread and drink this cup, you proclaim the Lord’s death till He comes” (1 Corinthians 11:26).

It is important, however, to speak with theological care. To continue observing the Passover apart from Christ is to miss its fulfillment. The feast, rightly understood, finds its meaning only in Him.

Let us now consider the words of institution. Taking the cup, and after giving thanks, Jesus said: *“Drink from it, all of you. For this is My blood of the new covenant, which is shed for many for the remission of sins”* (Matthew 26:27-28, NKJV). His words reveal a twofold significance in His shed blood: first, it secures the remission of sins; second, it establishes the New Covenant.

The Lord’s Supper, therefore, is a symbolic yet profound participation in these realities. It directs our faith to the atoning death of Christ, by which God’s righteous wrath against sin is satisfied, and it reminds us that we are beneficiaries and participants in the New Covenant inaugurated by His blood.

The taproot of the Lord's Supper lies in the Passover. It cannot be rightly understood in isolation from it. To grasp the meaning of the Lord's Supper, we must first understand the essence of the Passover.

What, then, is that essence?

The Passover was a memorial feast ordained by the Lord (Yahweh) for Israel, commemorating two foundational realities:

1. Deliverance from divine judgment

God's judgment came upon Egypt in the form of the death of the firstborn. Yet the Israelites were spared—not because of their merit, but because of the blood of a spotless lamb applied to their doorposts. As Scripture declares: “*When I see the blood, I will pass over you; and the plague shall not be on you to destroy you*” (Exodus 12:13).

Thus, salvation came through substitutionary sacrifice and the application of blood.

2. Covenant relationship with God

This deliverance led to a covenant. At Mount Sinai (Exodus 24), the covenant between Yahweh and Israel was ratified through the shedding and sprinkling of blood. Moses declared: *“This is the blood of the covenant which the Lord has made with you”* (Exodus 24:8). Blood not only saved—it bound God and His people in a covenant relationship.

Conclusion

This, then, is the significance of Jesus instituting the Lord’s Supper during the final Passover. Everything the Passover anticipated—deliverance through blood and covenant through sacrifice—finds its ultimate fulfillment in Christ.

The Lord’s Supper is, therefore, the fulfilled Passover: not a shadow, but the reality; not a promise, but its accomplishment.



Hypothetical Situation #2

The Question

Assume you are the pastor of a well-known church in the city. A young adult approaches you and asks:

“Pastor, when our Lord Jesus instituted the Lord’s Supper, He commanded, ‘*Do this in remembrance of Me*’ (Luke 22:19b, NKJV). But how can I remember something I have not personally experienced? What did Jesus mean, and how can I obey this command?”

How would you respond?

The Answer

That is an important and perceptive question. Jesus’ command, “*Do this in remembrance of Me,*” contains two inseparable dimensions: **the**

act itself (“Do this”) and **the purpose** (“in remembrance of Me”). These must not be divided, for they belong together—like form and meaning. The rite is a symbolic presentation that helps us remember the Lord and His works of salvation, and helps us identify ourselves as united with Him and with fellow believers. Therefore, only by doing the rite can we remember the Lord.

The Lord has given us not merely an idea to recall, but **a rite to perform**, through which remembrance is made possible and meaningful.

“Do this” — The Act Instituted

Let us first consider the command, “Do this.”

When a master teaches an apprentice and says, “*Do this*,” the meaning is clear: *replicate what I have shown you—according to the same pattern, method, and intention*. Similarly, our Lord’s command carries the sense of faithful imitation.

This principle echoes the instruction God gave to Moses regarding the tabernacle: “*According to all that I show you ... just so you shall make it*” (Exodus 25:9).

Thus, in instituting the Lord's Supper, Jesus was not giving a vague suggestion but establishing a pattern to be followed by His disciples.

In the Upper Room, He:

1. Took bread,
2. Gave thanks to God,
3. Broke it,
4. Gave it to His disciples with words of institution.

He did likewise with the cup.

These actions are not incidental—they form the pattern of the rite. The thanksgiving (often called *eucharistia*) is especially significant, for it sets apart (consecrates) ordinary elements for a sacred purpose. The bread and the cup remain what they are in substance, yet they are **consecrated for holy use**—to signify the body and blood of Christ.

It is therefore fitting that those who administer the Lord's Supper do so with reverence, thanksgiving, and faithfulness to the pattern given by the Lord. The minister does not act as the host of the table, but as a servant of

Christ, carrying out what the Lord Himself instituted.

“In remembrance of Me” — The Meaning of Remembrance

Now we come to the heart of your question: How can we remember what we have not experienced?

In Scripture, **remembrance is not mere mental recall**. It is a **covenantal, participatory act**. This is especially clear in the Passover, which forms the background to the Lord's Supper.

God commanded Israel: *“This day shall be to you a memorial ... throughout your generations”* (Exodus 12:14).

Later generations did not witness the Exodus firsthand. Yet, by faithfully observing the Passover according to God's command, they did not merely think about the event—**they entered into its meaning and shared in its significance**.

In this biblical sense, remembrance is **re-presentation**, not repetition; **participation**, not mere recollection.

An Illustration

Consider a couple celebrating their 25th wedding anniversary by renewing their vows in the same place, with the same words and symbols. They are not recreating the past in a literal sense, but **entering it afresh**, allowing its meaning to shape their present experience.

Similarly, when believers partake of the Lord's Supper, they are not transported back in time, but brought into **living communion with the crucified and risen Christ**.

The Meaning of the Command

We may therefore understand Jesus' command, "*Do this in remembrance of Me,*" in this way:

‘Perform this ordinance exactly as instituted and administered it in the Upper Room by Jesus Christ, according to all that He has shown, in the same pattern, using the same elements He

used, and receiving the same spiritual benefits His disciples received then.’

In doing so:

- We proclaim His death,
- We commune with Him by faith,
- We identify ourselves with His body—the Church,
- And we receive the spiritual benefits of His finished work.

Conclusion

So, you are not being asked to remember an event you never experienced. Rather, you are being invited to **enter into that once-for-all event through the means Christ Himself has appointed.**

The Lord’s Supper is not merely a reminder—it is a means of grace, where **remembrance becomes communion (or sharing, or participation) in the body and blood of Jesus Christ, with the spiritual efficacy of the rite as per 1 Corinthians 10:16.**



Hypothetical Situation #3

The Question

Assume you are the pastor of a well-known church in the city. A young adult approaches you and asks:

“Pastor, what is the big deal about the Lord’s Supper? It is said that its purpose is to remember Jesus. But we can remember Him while eating boiled cassava and drinking buttermilk. Since those are more natural to our Kerala culture, why don’t we use them for the Lord’s Supper?”

How would you respond?

The Answer

That is a thoughtful and culturally sensitive question. However, the Lord’s Supper is not

something we are free to redesign to suit cultural preferences. It is something we have **received from the Lord and are called to faithfully observe as He instituted it.**

1. The Lord's Supper is Instituted by Christ, Not Invented by Us

Our Lord Jesus Christ is the instituter, the first administrator, and the host of the table. He consecrated a single loaf of unleavened bread and a cup of wine (fruit of the vine) to signify His body and blood. It is He who appointed the signs and assigned them meanings through His unfailing words of institution. Note that the elements used by our Lord for this rite are from the table of the Passover Feast. So, it becomes a requirement that the church, in turn, use the same elements and pattern to make it meaningful. Therefore, replacing the unleavened bread and wine (fruit of the vine) with other substances for this rite is considered an aberration. It is noteworthy that sacred scripture has already appointed these elements as signs, assigning them specific meanings. The following are some references:

Leaven as a Type of Sin	Exodus 12:15; 13:3, 6-7; Leviticus 2:11; Deuteronomy 16:3-4; Matthew 16:6; Mark 8:15; 1 Corinthians 5:6-8; Galatians 5:9
Bread as a Type of Life	Genesis 14:18; Deuteronomy 8:3; Ecclesiastes 9:7; Matthew 4:4; John 6:11; 32-33; 35 & 5
Wine/Vine as a type of Joy/Life/Israel/Jesus	Genesis 14:18; Judges 9:13; Psalms 80:14-17; 104:15; Isaiah 5:7; Jeremiah 2:21; Hosea 10:1; John 15:1

Our Lord Jesus Christ gave specific meaning through His words: *“This is My body ... This is My blood of the new covenant”* (Matthew 26:26-28).

These elements are not arbitrary. They are **divinely chosen signs**, rooted in the Passover meal and fulfilled in Christ. Since He instituted both the **elements** and their **meaning**, the Church is not at liberty to substitute them. To alter the elements is not merely to adapt—it is to **depart from the form Christ Himself gave**.

2. The Unity of Sign and Meaning

In the Lord's Supper, there is a vital relationship between the **signs** (bread and wine) and what they **signify** (the body and blood of Christ).

- The bread signifies life given for us.
- The cup signifies the blood of the covenant, shed for the remission of sins.

These meanings are not assigned by us, but by Christ Himself. Therefore, we cannot separate the meaning from the sign, nor replace the sign while keeping the meaning intact.

There is a clear distinction between the signs and what they signify; that is to say, that the signs are not what they signify. Or, the signs do not become what they represent. Yet the signs must convey to the participant what they signify. Otherwise, Jesus' words of institution will become mere empty words. And that will never happen. Why? Because it is written, and I quote: "*It is impossible for God to lie*" (Hebrews 6:18); "*God is not a man, that He should lie, Nor a son of man, that He should repent. Has He said, and will He not do? Or has He spoken, and will He not make it good?*" (Numbers 23:19)

3. The Purpose: Not Mere Remembrance, but Communion

Some people are confused about the fundamental purpose of the Lord's Supper. The fundamental purpose of the Lord's Supper is not remembrance, but communion (*koinonia*) (1 Cor. 10:16). Remembrance, in Scripture, is not merely mental recollection. It is **participatory and covenantal**. The command, "*Do this in remembrance of Me*," is the method by which Jesus communicates His being to the believer. How? In the same way, the sacrificed body and the shed blood of the Pascal lamb are communicated to the partaker during the actual Passover. In the same way, a participant in the sacrifice offered on the altar of YAHWEH becomes a participant with YAHWEH. We read, 'Observe Israel after the flesh: Are not those who eat of the sacrifices partakers of the altar?' (1 Corinthians 10:18). The altar erected in the name of YAHWEH represents YAHWEH. A sacrificial offering placed on that altar becomes one with YAHWEH. If I eat a portion of it, I become a partaker of YAHWEH through the

altar. The same divine principle applies here. Hence, Apostle Paul exhorts us, ‘*You cannot drink the cup of the Lord and the cup of demons; you cannot partake of the Lord’s table and of the table of demons.*’ (1Corinthians 10:21).

4. The Role of Faith and the Holy Spirit

The Apostle Paul writes:

“The cup of blessing which we bless, is it not the communion (koinonia) of the blood of Christ? The bread which we break, is it not the communion of the body of Christ?” (1 Corinthians 10:16).

The Lord’s Supper is therefore not only a memorial—it is **communion**: a real participation in Christ **by faith, mediated by the Holy Spirit**. It is the agent, Holy Spirit, who fulfills this communion (*koinonia*) **in the spiritual realm through the faith of the participant**. Therefore, the absence of true faith and the Holy Spirit makes this rite a mere empty formula, a meaningless ritual.

5. The Theology of Participation in Christ

Jesus Himself spoke of this deep, life-giving participation:

“I am the bread of life... If anyone eats of this bread, he will live forever” (John 6:48-51).

“He who eats My flesh and drinks My blood abides in Me, and I in him” (John 6:56).

These words point to the profound reality that Christ gives His life to His people. The Lord's Supper is a visible and tangible proclamation of this truth. This act of communicating His life to the believer is known as ‘Holy Communion’.

Jesus reinforced the said objective with the first miracle He performed, which He performed as a **sign** at the wedding in Cana of Galilee. What did He do? He infused (communicated) the plain water with the properties of the superior wine. As you will appreciate, the plain water is a simile of the sinner, and the wine is a simile of our Lord Jesus. Later on, Jesus claimed that He is the true

vine and that the disciples are its branches (John 15:1, 5). By this claim, Jesus reinforces the fact that His believers are abiding in Him as one being. It is the same vine-life that runs through the branches. It signifies that believers are united to Christ, sharing in His life, and united to one another as one body: “*For we, though many, are **one bread and one body**; for we all partake of that **one bread***” (1 Corinthians 10:17).

Be it known that the rite of the Lord’s Supper is a **symbolic presentation**, demonstrating the believers’ oneness with the Lord Jesus Christ and fellow believers. Therefore, using more than one bread and one cup in this rite destroys the symbolism assigned by our Lord. The participants must drink from the same consecrated wine. Why? From the words of the institution, “***Drink from it (or of it), all of you***”, it becomes mandatory that the participants share from the same wine that has been consecrated for the holy purpose. Without partaking in His body and blood, that oneness cannot be achieved.

6. Cultural Relevance vs. Divine Institution

Your suggestion about cassava and buttermilk raises an important principle: **the gospel transcends culture, but the sacraments are governed by Christ's institution.**

While the Church may express many things in culturally meaningful ways, the Lord's Supper is not one of them. It is not ours to reshape, because it is **a sign given by the Lord Himself.**

7. A Final Clarification

The Lord's Supper is not a means of earning salvation. Scripture is clear: we are saved by grace through faith (Ephesians 2:8-9). Rather, the Supper is given to those who believe a) to nourish their faith, b) to strengthen their communion with Christ, and c) to deepen their fellowship with His body.

Conclusion

So, why not cassava and buttermilk? Because the Lord's Supper is not about what feels

meaningful to us, but about **faithfully receiving what Christ has given**. In this sacred meal, we do not create meaning—we **enter into the meaning He has already established**:

- a) His body given for us,
- b) His blood shed for us, and
- c) our life hidden in Him.



Hypothetical Situation #4

The Question

Assume you are the pastor of a well-known church in the city. A young adult approaches you and asks:

“Pastor, I’ve noticed that in many churches—Pentecostal, Evangelical, Catholic, and others—the bread used in the Lord’s Supper is often not visibly broken before the congregation. Instead, individuals receive a wafer or a small piece and eat it as a whole. Is the act of breaking the bread an essential element in administering the Lord’s Supper?”

How would you respond?

The Answer

Yes, the breaking of the bread is a necessary and theologically significant act in the administration of the Lord's Supper. This is not merely a matter of tradition, but of fidelity to the pattern established by Christ Himself.

In the institution of the Supper, we read:

“And He took bread, gave thanks and broke it, and gave it to them, saying, ‘This is My body which is given for you; do this in remembrance of Me’” (Luke 22:19, NKJV).

The command, *“Do this in remembrance of Me,”* calls the Church not only to remember Christ, but to observe the ordinance in the manner He instituted it—following His pattern, employing His appointed elements, and participating in its intended spiritual realities. Because the Lord's Supper is a divinely instituted sign, **every action within it carries theological meaning.** The breaking of the bread is therefore not incidental, but integral to its symbolism.

First, breaking bread visibly proclaims the suffering and death of Christ on behalf of sinners. It signifies that His body was given over to suffering and death, and that His blood was shed for the remission of sins. Just as grain is crushed and processed to become bread that sustains physical life, so Christ, bearing the sin of the world, was subjected to suffering and death to become the source of eternal life for all who repent and believe. The act of breaking thus serves as a vivid, enacted proclamation of the cross.

Second, the breaking of one loaf into many portions signifies the unity of Christ and His Church. Christ is the Head, and believers are members of His body. When many partake of the one broken loaf, it visibly expresses their participation in the one body of Christ and their union with one another in Him. As the Apostle Paul writes, “*The bread which we break, is it not the communion of the body of Christ?*” (1 Corinthians 10:16). Without the breaking of the bread, this corporate and participatory symbolism is obscured.

Third, the Supper signifies the believer's spiritual participation in the life of the risen Christ. In partaking worthily, believers commune with Christ—not in a merely symbolic or memorial sense alone, but in a real spiritual participation. Christ communicates Himself—His life—to His people. Thus, the Supper also points to the indwelling Christ, “*the hope of glory*” (Colossians 1:27), and the believer's ongoing nourishment in Him.

Furthermore, the practice of the early Church reinforces the centrality of this act. The apostolic communities gathered on the first day of the week with the expressed purpose of “*breaking bread*” (Acts 20:7). This phrase is not incidental; it reflects the recognized and defining act of their corporate worship in relation to the Lord's Supper. It is not merely a reference to a common meal, **but to the sacramental breaking of bread in obedience to Christ's command.**

For these reasons, the practice of distributing pre-broken, unbroken wafers (such as ‘*osthi*’) risks diminishing the richness of the ordinance's symbolism. While such practices may arise

from practical considerations, they can obscure the visible proclamation of Christ's broken body and the shared participation of believers in one loaf.

Therefore, the breaking of the bread should be retained as a meaningful and necessary element in the administration of the Lord's Supper, in keeping with the pattern established by Christ and the theological depth embedded in the ordinance.

I trust your confusion is now cleared.



Hypothetical Situation #5

The Question

Assume you are the pastor of a well-known church in the city. A young adult approaches you and says:

“Pastor, each time we celebrate the Lord’s Supper, we read 1 Corinthians 11:23-32 as part of its administration. I would like to draw your attention particularly to verses 27-30:

*‘Therefore, whoever eats this bread or drinks this cup of the Lord in an unworthy manner will be guilty of the body and blood of the Lord. But let a man examine himself, and so let him eat of the bread and drink of the cup. For he who eats and drinks in an **unworthy manner** eats and drinks judgment to himself, not discerning the Lord’s body. For this reason,*

many are weak and sick among you, and many sleep.'

What exactly does the expression 'in an unworthy manner' mean?"

How would you respond?

The Answer

You have raised a profoundly important and necessary question. The phrase rendered in the *New King James Version* as "in an unworthy manner" appears in slightly varied forms across translations, some emphasizing "unworthily" or "in a manner unworthy of the Lord." The nuance of the expression is significant and must be carefully understood within its theological and covenantal context.

Scripture, when examined holistically, reveals that "unworthiness" in relation to the Lord's Supper may be understood under two distinct yet related categories:

- (1) the unworthiness of the participant, and
- (2) the unworthiness in the manner of participation.

1. The Unworthiness of the Participant

First, it must be recognized that participation in the Lord's Supper is discriminatory. It is a covenantal meal, reserved for those who stand within the New Covenant established in the blood of Christ. This principle finds its precedent in the Old Covenant institution of the Passover.

The Passover was not open to all; it was restricted to those within the covenant community of Israel. The uncircumcised and the ceremonially unclean were excluded (*cf.* Genesis 17:10-14; Exodus 12:48; Numbers 9:6-11). Circumcision functioned as the covenantal sign marking one's inclusion among the people of God.

In like manner, the Lord's Supper belongs exclusively to those who are participants in the New Covenant. The corresponding covenantal sign is baptism—entered into upon hearing and believing the gospel. Through baptism, one is united with Christ in His death, burial, and resurrection (*cf.* Romans 6:3-8), and thereby incorporated into Him. Only those who are thus

in union with Christ are proper participants in this ordinance. Communion presupposes union; where union with Christ is absent, participation becomes illegitimate.

Participation in the Lord's Supper signifies your union and communion with Christ. Therefore, there cannot be communion without union with Christ, evidenced by faith and baptism.

Another prohibition is on persons incapable of, or unwilling to, engage in self-examination. The apostolic injunction is explicit. We read, *'But let a man examine himself, and so let him eat of the bread and drink of the cup.'* (1 Corinthians 11:28). The inability to self-examine can be due to either a lack of knowledge or immaturity. Such people are also unworthy of the Lord to participating in the Lord's Supper. This examination **involves discerning the body of Christ** in a twofold sense:

- the incarnate, crucified body of the Lord Jesus Christ, and
- His corporate body, the Church (*cf.* 1 Corinthians 10:17; 12:12-13, 27; Romans 12:5; Ephesians 5:23).

Additionally, Scripture warns against idolatry as a disqualifying condition. Idolatry, whether expressed outwardly or entertained inwardly, constitutes spiritual adultery and violates covenant fidelity (*cf.* 1 Corinthians 10). While many may abstain from overt, physical idolatry, subtle forms persist in the realm of the mind—particularly when God is conceived, represented, or approached through images, icons, or imagined forms. Such practices attribute divine glory to created representations, thereby transgressing the fundamental commandments concerning the worship of God. This inward corruption renders a person unfit to partake of the Lord's Table.

2. The unworthiness in the Manner of Participation

A worthy participant can receive the elements of the Lord's Supper in an unworthy *manner*. The elements of the Lord's Supper—the bread and the cup—are divinely appointed signs that signify the body and blood of Christ. While they do not become the literal body and blood, their symbolic significance is not to be

treated lightly or irreverently. They are sacred signs pointing to the redemptive work of Christ.

We need to be cautious about how we receive the bread and wine. We should fearfully and reverently remember the role of Jesus Christ in the redemptive works. He is the sacrifice (the offering). He is the high priest who offered this sacrifice in His eternal spirit. He is the mediator of the New Covenant. He is the institutor of the rite of the Lord's Supper. He is the host of the table. And His immediate presence is with us. So, one who participates in the Lord's Supper without acknowledging the assigned meanings of the signs, without examining his relationship to them, and without reverence and fear of the Lord is participating in it in an *unworthy manner*. Apostle Paul warns the Corinthians about the severe consequences of such participation. We read, '*That is why many among you are weak and sick, and a number of you have fallen asleep.*' (1 Corinthians 11:30 NIV). These consequences underscore the seriousness with which God regards the proper observance of this ordinance.

Conclusion

“In an unworthy manner,” therefore, does not merely refer to moral imperfection, but to a failure to align one’s status and conduct with the covenantal, spiritual, and theological realities signified in the Lord’s Supper. It encompasses both the participant’s eligibility and the reverence for participation.

To approach the Lord’s Table rightly is to come as one who is in covenant with Christ, who discerns His body, who walks in fidelity to Him, and who partakes with humility, faith, and holy reverence.



Hypothetical Situation #6

The Question

Assume you are the pastor of a well-known church in the city. A young adult approaches you and asks:

“Pastor, whenever we celebrate the Lord’s Supper, we read 1 Corinthians 11:23-32 as part of its administration. In particular, verses 27-30 say:

‘Therefore, whoever eats this bread or drinks this cup of the Lord in an unworthy manner will be guilty of the body and blood of the Lord. But let a man examine himself, and so let him eat of the bread and drink of the cup. For he who eats and drinks in an unworthy manner eats and drinks judgment to himself, not discerning the Lord’s body. For this reason,

many are weak and sick among you, and many sleep.'

This passage seems to indicate that one who partakes without discerning the Lord's body becomes guilty of the body and blood of Christ.

What do these expressions mean:

(a) 'guilty of the body and blood of the Lord,'
and

(b) 'discerning the body of the Lord'?

How would you respond?

The Answer

(a) "Guilty of the Body and Blood of the Lord."

We begin with a basic moral principle: guilt presupposes the violation of a divine command. In this passage, the command is clear—"*let a man examine himself,*" which Paul further defines as *discerning the Lord's body*.

Thus, the one who partakes of the bread and the cup without such discernment stands guilty.

But guilty of what? Paul's language is striking: "*guilty of the body and blood of the Lord.*" This is not a mere ritual failure; it is covenantal and moral culpability. To treat the signs of Christ's sacrifice without recognition of their divine significance is to stand in continuity with those who crucified Him.

Consider the Roman soldiers. In nailing Jesus to the cross, they acted in ignorance, yet objectively they committed an act of profound injustice—they shed innocent blood. They did not perceive that Christ was dying for them as their substitute. They were actually '*profaning and sinning against the body and blood of the Lord.*' Therefore, each soldier must pay the penalty of a death sentence for violating God's commandment, "*You shall not murder.*"

In a similar way, the unworthy participant ***who did not discern the Lord's body*** is equated to the Roman soldier who profaned the Lord's body. He fails to acknowledge the atoning significance of Christ's death. In doing so, he aligns himself, not with faith, but with disregard. The result is that he stands, in a real sense, accountable for the very body and blood

he treats lightly. As the Roman soldier, the unworthy participant stands before the heavenly court charged with first-degree murder. This is why Paul speaks of judgment: such a participant incurs divine discipline, even to the extent of weakness, sickness, and death.

(b) ‘Discerning the Body of the Lord.’

To discern the Lord’s body is to rightly perceive, embrace, and respond to the reality signified in the bread and the cup.

Our Lord appointed bread and wine as visible signs of His body and blood and invested them with meaning through His words of institution. These signs are not empty symbols; they are divinely ordained means through which spiritual realities are communicated. The signs and their meaning must not be separated. The visible elements are earthly signs of a heavenly reality. In the rite of the Lord’s Supper, which is conducted without distortion, the meaning of the signs is conveyed to the participant spiritually. Therefore, at the heart of the Supper is *communion* (*koinonia*). As Paul writes:

“The cup of blessing which we bless, is it not the communion of the blood of Christ? The bread which we break, is it not the communion of the body of Christ?” (1 Corinthians 10:16)

This communion is effected by the Holy Spirit and received through faith. Apart from the Spirit’s work and the participant’s faith, the ordinance degenerates into an empty ritual.

To discern the Lord’s body, therefore, involves recognizing two inseparable dimensions: (1) The Incarnate and Crucified Body of Christ, and (2) The Risen Body of Christ — His Church. The participant has a relation to both aspects of the Lord’s body. Therefore, he should recognize, know, acknowledge, and identify himself with those two aspects. Only then will the self-examination requirement be completed.

1. The Incarnate and Crucified Body of Christ

The participant must recognize who Christ is and what He has accomplished. Jesus Christ is God the Son, who assumed true human nature by the power of the Holy Spirit in the womb of

the Virgin Mary. In His incarnate life, He bore a sinless human nature—fully human, yet without sin.

According to the law of God, sin demands death: *“The soul who sins shall die”* (Ezekiel 18:20a NKJV); *“For the wages of sin is death”*. (Romans 6:23a NKJV). In His body, Christ bore the penalty due to sinners. His death was substitutionary—He died for us and in our place. The sacred scripture attests to this truth. We read, *‘The law of Moses was unable to save us because of the weakness of our sinful nature. So God did what the law could not do. He sent his own Son in a body like the bodies we sinners have. And in that body, God declared an end to sin’s control over us by giving his Son as a sacrifice for our sins. He did this so that the just requirement of the law would be fully satisfied for us, who no longer follow our sinful nature but instead follow the Spirit.’* (Romans 8:3-4 NLT).

To discern His body, then, is to acknowledge:

- that our guilt was laid upon Him,
- that His death satisfied the righteous requirement of the law, and

- that His suffering and death were on our behalf.

Thus, when the bread is broken, and the cup is shared, the participant must consciously identify with Christ's death—recognizing that his sin was judged in Christ's body. This conscious acknowledgment, joined with faith, constitutes true discernment.

2. The Risen Body of Christ — His Church

The second dimension of discernment concerns the corporate body of Christ. The risen Christ is not isolated from His people; He is united with them. He is the Head, and the Church is His body. All believers are members of this one living organism.

The **one bread** signifies this unity: “*For we, though many, are **one bread** and **one body**.*” To partake rightly, therefore, is to recognize not only Christ's sacrifice but also one's union with His people. Hence, the requirement that only one bread must be broken in this ordinance. A fragment of the bread shows that it is part of the

whole. A participant should remind himself that he is part of that one whole body. Hence, the requirement for him to be at peace and in harmony with all fellow believers. That unity is disrupted when a participant is jealous, in strife, in dissension, and quarreling with other believers (participants). Such a participant destroys the symbolism our Lord has incorporated in this rite. Destroying God-ordained symbols and their symbolism matters to God. The sacred scriptures reveal that truth. The punishment of Moses (Numbers 20:7-12) and Nadab and Abihu (Leviticus 10:1-3) are perfect examples before us. Therefore, one who refuses reconciliation while participating in the Supper acts contrary to its meaning. It is better for such a person to abstain than to partake in a manner that contradicts the unity of Christ's body.



Hypothetical Situation #7

The Question

Assume you are the pastor of a well-known church in the city. A young adult approaches you and asks:

“Pastor, when instituting the Lord’s Supper, after giving thanks for the cup, our Lord Jesus said, *‘Drink from it, all of you. For this is My blood of the new covenant, which is shed for many for the remission of sins’* (Matthew 26:27-28, NKJV).

What did Jesus mean when He said, *‘This is My blood of the new covenant, which is shed for many for the remission of sins’*?

How would you explain this?

The Answer

Before addressing your question directly, it is important to notice the opening command of Jesus: “*Drink from it, all of you.*” In other English versions, it is “*Drink of it, all of you.*” This is not incidental.

As you know, our Lord instituted the Lord’s Supper whilst celebrating the Passover Feast of the Old Covenant. According to the Jewish tradition prevailing at the time of Jesus, four cups of wine would be placed on the table before each participant. Each cup is to be drunk ceremonially at different times of the rite. Jesus did not instruct them to drink from the cup that was before them. Instead, *He instructed them to drink from the same cup (i.e., from the same wine) for which He gave thanks to God and thus consecrated for the holy purpose.*

Incidentally, the word ‘consecrate’ simply means separating or dedicating the common for a holy purpose. What is the relevance? This is theologically significant. Drinking from an unconsecrated wine distorts the rite of the Lord’s Supper. How? If the bread and wine are

not consecrated by prayer and thanksgiving, their status remains unholy (common). When unholy elements are used, the rite is distorted; it is not the Lord's Supper that you eat. Therefore, consecrating the elements for the holy purpose is a quintessential step in the administration of the Lord's Supper.

Now, to your central question.

The words of Jesus—often called *the words of institution*—reveal the twofold significance of His shed blood.

First, His blood is shed “*for the remission of sins*.” This speaks of atonement. Through His sacrificial death, Jesus bears the penalty of sin, satisfying the righteous demands of God and securing forgiveness for sinners who believe in Him.

Second, His blood establishes the *new covenant*. In Scripture, covenants are ratified by the shedding of blood. The Hebrew concept of covenant (*berith*) carries the idea of “cutting,” pointing to sacrificial bloodshed. The Abrahamic and Mosaic covenants were inaugurated through the blood of animals. In

contrast, the new covenant is established through the blood of Christ Himself.

In this covenant, God the Father enters into a covenantal relationship with Jesus Christ, who stands as the representative of His people. Christ, as the sinless mediator, represents all who belong to Him—past, present, and future. Thus, the Church becomes the beneficiary of this covenant through union with Christ.

An illustration of this principle can be seen in the covenant between David and Jonathan (1 Samuel 20:14-15). Though Jonathan's descendants were not yet born, they were included in the covenant. Consequently, Mephibosheth, though politically an enemy of David, received covenantal kindness (*hesed*—steadfast, covenantal love). In a similar but far greater way, believers are included in the new covenant through Christ, their covenant head.

Returning to the Lord's Supper: the cup represents the blood of Christ, shed to inaugurate this covenant. Though Jesus had not yet been crucified when He spoke these words, He was prophetically declaring and instituting

what He would accomplish the following day. The covenant was instituted in the Upper Room and ratified at the cross.

This pattern corresponds with the Old Covenant. As Hebrews 9:18 reminds us, “*not even the first covenant was dedicated without blood.*” In Exodus 24:5-8, Moses sprinkles blood on both the altar and the people, declaring, “*This is the blood of the covenant.*” Jesus deliberately echoes this language, identifying Himself as both the sacrifice and the mediator of a greater covenant.

Moreover, the sacrificial system of the Old Covenant helps us understand the fullness of Christ’s work. The **burnt offering** signifies the bearing of divine judgment—substitutionary atonement. The **peace offering** signifies reconciliation and restored fellowship with God, often expressed in a shared meal.

In the new covenant, these realities converge in one person—Jesus Christ. He is both the sacrifice and the High Priest. As Hebrews 9:11-14 teaches, He entered the heavenly sanctuary

with His own blood, securing eternal redemption.

Thus, when believers partake of the Lord's Supper, the cup functions as a **sign and seal** of the New Covenant. It visibly assures participants, the beneficiaries of the covenant, that all the blessings (i.e., the promises) of the New Covenant will be fulfilled for them.

The cup of wine, signifying the shed blood of Jesus, also assures the participant of *peace with God*, for it is Jesus' shed blood that propitiates (appeases) an angry God and unites the participant with the triune God. How?

The Old Covenant was established with the shed blood of animals offered as a Burnt Offering and a Peace Offering. The victim of the burnt offering takes on the punishment for the sins of the offerer. Once the offerer's guilt of sin is punished in the animal, which is without any blemish, the offerer is rescued from the punishment of God. Thus, the righteous character of God is satisfied. But to enable the sinner to walk with God, he must also be reconciled to God. That is where the

significance of the Peace Offering steps in. The peace offering is also known as the ‘Thanksgiving offering’. The peace offering is the only sacrifice where Yahweh and the offerer share the offering, like in a table fellowship. We read, *‘This is the law of the sacrifice of peace offerings which he shall offer to the Lord: If he offers it for a thanksgiving, then he shall offer, with the sacrifice of thanksgiving, unleavened cakes mixed with oil, unleavened wafers anointed with oil, or cakes of blended flour mixed with oil. Besides the cakes, as his offering, he shall offer leavened bread with the sacrifice of thanksgiving of his peace offering. And from it he shall offer one cake from each offering as a heave offering to the Lord. **It shall belong to the priest who sprinkles the blood of the peace offering.** ‘The flesh of the sacrifice of his peace offering for thanksgiving shall be eaten the same day it is offered. He shall not leave any of it until morning.’* (Leviticus 7:11-15 NKJV). The priest who sprinkles the blood of the peace offering represents Yahweh. In the New Covenant, the rite of the Lord’s Supper is a thanksgiving offering. Hence, the name ‘Eucharist’. The term

‘Eucharist’ originates from the Greek word eucharista, meaning thanksgiving (gratitude).

In the New Covenant, the Burnt Offering, the Peace Offering, and the Priest who offered these sacrifices are all one person. That person is Jesus Christ, our Lord. He is the victim of the sacrifice and the high priest according to the order of Melchizedek, who sprinkled His own shed blood on the mercy seat of God in His eternal spirit. The sacred scripture attests to this truth. We read, *‘But Christ came as High Priest of the good things to come, with the greater and more perfect tabernacle not made with hands, that is, not of this creation. Not with the blood of goats and calves, but with His own blood, He entered the Most Holy Place once for all, having obtained eternal redemption. For if the blood of bulls and goats and the ashes of a heifer, sprinkling the unclean, sanctifies for the purifying of the flesh, how much more shall the blood of Christ, who through the eternal Spirit offered Himself without spot to God, cleanse your conscience from dead works to serve the living God?’* (Hebrews 9:11-14).

I also want to draw your attention to Jesus' discourse with His disciples in the Upper Room after instituting the Lord's Supper. John's gospel, chapter 14, gives an account of the conversation that took place in the Upper Room. Jesus said, '**Peace** I leave with you; **my peace** I give to you. *Not as the world gives do I give to you. Let not your hearts be troubled, neither let them be afraid.*' (John 14:27 ESV). What is this peace Jesus is talking about? A sinner is at enmity with God. As an enemy of God, he can only expect to receive God's wrath. People of the world offer peace by saying, 'Shalom' or 'Peace be with you' or '*as-salamu alaykum*' ("and upon you be peace"). But these words of well-wishing cannot give them peace with an angry God. The monopoly of peace that secures friendship with God belongs to Jesus. Hence, Jesus labeled this peace as '*My Peace*'. Foreseeing Him becoming a Burnt Offering and a Peace Offering the next day, Jesus said those words to His disciples. The institute of the Lord's Supper stands parallel to the peace offering of the Old Covenant. Our Lord Jesus, as the High Priest, took unleavened bread in His hands and, after

consecrating it, broke it and gave it to the disciples, saying, *“Take, eat; this is my body”*. And He took the cup, and when He had given thanks, He gave it to the disciples, saying, *‘Drink from it, all of you. For this is My blood of the new covenant, which is shed for many for the remission of sins.’*

A sinner receives the remission of sins through his faith in Jesus Christ, the Lamb of God, and His shed blood (i.e., His works of salvation). When a participant eats the bread and drinks the cup of the Lord’s Supper in a worthy manner (or worthy of the Lord), the assigned significance of the signs is conveyed to the participant by the word of His power (Hebrews 1:3; Psalms 33:9). It is the agent Holy Spirit who fulfills this spiritual communion based on the faith of the participant.

Jesus, by becoming a **burnt offering** (also known as a sin offering), rescued sinners from the wrath of God to come. And Jesus, by becoming a **peace offering** and having removed the enmity, reconciled sinners to God.

Finally, the Lord's Supper is not a repetition of Christ's sacrifice, but a **means of grace**—a divinely appointed ordinance through which the benefits of His once-for-all sacrifice are spiritually communicated to believers. When received in faith, the Holy Spirit confirms and strengthens the believer's assurance of forgiveness, righteousness, and communion with God.

Therefore, participation in the Lord's Supper is a profound privilege—it is a covenantal act in which believers are reminded, assured, and nourished by the saving work of Christ.



Hypothetical Situation #8

The Question

Assume you are the pastor of a well-known church in the city. A young adult approaches you and asks:

“Pastor, the Apostle Paul emphasizes the necessity of self-examination in the Lord’s Supper by pointing to the divine judgment that fell upon some members of the Corinthian church. He says that because of unworthy participation, many were weak, ill, and some had even died:

*‘But let a man examine himself, and so let him eat of the bread and drink of the cup. For he who eats and drinks in an unworthy manner eats and drinks judgment to himself, not discerning the Lord’s body. **For this reason,***

many are weak and sick among you, and many sleep.’ (1 Corinthians 11:28-30, NKJV)

Yet we do not seem to observe such judgments in the church today. Does this mean that believers now partake worthily? If not, in what ways might the Lord’s Supper be distorted in contemporary practice?”

How would you respond?

The Answer

It would indeed be comforting to conclude that all believers today partake of the Lord’s Supper in a worthy manner. However, such a conclusion does not withstand theological scrutiny. The character of God is immutable; He does not change. If divine judgment once accompanied unworthy participation, it cannot be dismissed as though it were no longer relevant.

While it is true that God is patient and long-suffering, the absence of visible judgment today should not be hastily interpreted as evidence of universal worthiness. Rather, the apostolic rebuke itself provides a crucial insight. Writing

between AD 53 and 55, Paul tells the Corinthians:

*“When you come together, **it is not the Lord’s supper that you eat.**”* (1 Corinthians 11:20, ESV)

This statement indicates that distortions of the Lord’s Supper had already arisen within the earliest generation of the Church. What was being practiced outwardly resembled the rite, yet in substance it had ceased to be the Lord’s Supper.

This observation has profound implications. Across Christendom today, there exists no unified doctrine or practice concerning the Lord’s Supper. Interpretations range from **Transubstantiation** to **Memorialism**, representing opposing extremes. Both these extreme views are equally heretical since they do not conform one hundred percent with the truths of the holy scripture. The reason for this is that people do not accept the infallibility of the word of God or faithfully adhere to the commands of our Lord Jesus. Since the taproot of the Lord’s Supper is embedded in the

Passover Feast, we must analyze the Lord's Supper in conjunction with the Passover Feast. Otherwise, distortions will certainly occur.

For this reason, it is not unreasonable to suggest that much of what is practiced today under the name of the Lord's Supper is already, in varying degrees, distorted. Where the rite itself is fundamentally altered, the question of "worthy" or "unworthy" participation becomes secondary, because what is being observed may no longer correspond to the ordinance Christ instituted. This helps explain the apparent absence of the specific judgments described in Corinth.

This leads us to a crucial question: **How can the Lord's Supper be distorted?**

At its core, any deviation from the pattern instituted by Christ constitutes distortion. The Lord's command, "Do this in remembrance of Me," is not merely a general instruction but a call to faithful adherence. It implies that the Church is to observe the Supper in continuity with the manner in which Christ Himself instituted and administered it—preserving its

elements, actions, and theological meaning. We infer the meaning of the Lord's command as follows:

'Doing the rite as Jesus instituted and administered in the Upper Room, according to all that He has shown, in the same pattern, using the same elements He used, and receiving the same spiritual benefits His disciples received then.'

I am convinced that administering the Lord's Supper is a serious matter to God.

Administrators' responsibility and accountability are comparable to that of Nadab and Abihu, who were ordained to offer incense in the holy place. They were commanded to light up their censers only with the consecrated fire from the altar of Yahweh. But they lit up their censers with strange (profaned) fire, i.e., unconsecrated (common) fire contrary to the command of Yahweh. And fire went out from the LORD and devoured them, and they died before the LORD (Leviticus 10:1-3).

Jesus' command carries the same weight as Yahweh's command in the Old Testament

because the Lord Jesus Christ, the Son of God, is one being with the Father and the Holy Spirit (the triune being, Yahweh). The place where believers assemble in the name of the Lord Jesus Christ to worship Him; His presence is immanent (Matthew 18:20). It is a holy place. Our Lord God is still a consuming fire (Deuteronomy 4:24; Hebrews 12:29). Therefore, we are responsible to minister the Lord's Supper without any distortions.

There are six possible ways in which the rite of the Lord's Supper can be distorted. They are:

1. Alteration of the Elements

When we use unleavened bread and drink anything other than the fruit of the vine to represent the body and blood of Jesus Christ, distortion occurs. Jesus, using the elements of the Passover Feast, appointed them as signs to represent His body and blood. The church must follow suit. The bread must be unleavened, made from wheat or barley, and baked in an oven or on charcoal. We should not replace the bread with steamed or boiled food (e.g., *vattayappam*, *idlis*, rice cakes) for this purpose.

Likewise, we should not replace the wine with other flavored juices. The drink must be an extract of grapes, the fruit of the vine. Why? The sacred scripture has already appointed leaven, bread, and wine (the fruit of the vine) as signs and symbols, assigning them specific meanings. These are not arbitrary but divinely appointed signs, rooted in the Passover and fulfilled in Christ. It is not right for us to change them. (Please refer to Question #3).

2. Failure to Consecrate the Elements

When participants partake of unconsecrated elements, distortion occurs. Consecrating elements for the holy use is a quintessential step in the administration of the Lord's Supper. The objective of the rite is to communicate the body and the blood of the risen Lord Jesus to the participant. The Holy Communion is fulfilled spiritually through the unfailing words of institution, the participant's faith, and the power of the Holy Spirit. Therefore, participating in unconsecrated elements destroys the purpose of the Lord's Supper. It is not the Lord's Supper that the participants eat.

3. Neglect of the Breaking of the Bread

When participants eat pre-broken bread, i.e., bread broken into pieces and kept ready before even believers assemble. According to the Apostolic tradition, the very purpose of assembling on Sunday is to break bread (Acts 20:7). The Lord's Supper is a rite of symbolic presentation. Therefore, participants must see the action of breaking the bread. It helps them connect with (or discern) the broken body of Jesus Christ (the body of sinful likeness). It also helps them connect with (or discern) the oneness of the risen body, the Church. Since our Lord has shown this pattern, the Church must follow suit. Thus, breaking the bread before the congregation is another quintessential step in administering the rite.

4. Substitution with Individual, Unbroken Portions

When participants eat unbroken, whole bread, like a single wafer/biscuit (ബസ്കിറ്റ്). Since the COVID-19 pandemic, this practice has spread widely to most denominations.

According to the pattern shown by our Lord, participants must break the bread and eat only a broken piece, not the whole. Eating a single wafer/biscuit (ബാസ്കറ്റ്) also destroys the sign of the participant being part of the body of Jesus Christ. The practice of eating a single wafer deviates from the objective of the Lord's Supper.

5. Use of Multiple Loaves

When the administrator breaks more than one bread, the rite is distorted. Again, churches follow this practice to meet convenience (a large crowd). When we break more than one bread in the Lord's Supper, we are destroying the symbolism of oneness and one body. We are not following the pattern shown by our Lord. We read, *'For we, though many, are **one bread** and **one body**; for we all partake of that **one bread**.'* (1 Corinthians 10:17 NKJV). *'There is **one body** and **one Spirit**, just as you were called in one hope of your calling; **one Lord**, **one faith**, **one baptism**; **one God and Father** of all, who is above all, and through all, and in you all.'* (Ephesians 4:4-6 NKJV).

6. Disconnection from the One Cup

When believers do not partake of the consecrated *single loaf and one cup*, distortion occurs. Among Evangelicals, Pentecostals, and other non-denominational churches, the practice nowadays is for the administrator to take one cup from the many cups arranged on a tray. And, after saying the words of institution, he drinks it. Believers have no participation in that cup of wine. Instead, they are drinking from the other cups kept in the tray. This practice is a clear distortion of the rite. We can have different cups, but the participation must be from the same wine that has been consecrated for the holy purpose. Otherwise, participants will not attain the communion of the Lord's body and blood.

In the Lord's Supper that has been conducted without distortion, anyone who eats and drinks without discerning the body (i.e., without examining himself) and in an unworthy manner eats and drinks judgment to himself.



SOLA SCRIPTURA

The phrase '*sola scriptura*', or 'by scripture alone', asserts that the Bible must determine church traditions and interpretations. All church practices and doctrines must be in unity with the teachings of the Scripture, the divinely inspired Word of God. This principle asserts that the Bible is to be interpreted by itself, with one passage of Scripture useful for interpreting other passages. It shows that the Bible is a unified system of truth and a revelation of truth. The teachings and customs of the church must align themselves with the Word of God; only then can they be applied with any assurance of God's approval and their own trustworthiness.

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THE LORD'S SUPPER

Distortions in the Ordinance

ALEX M KURUVILLA

The Lord's Supper is a divinely instituted ordinance grounded in covenant theology, apostolic practice, and Christological fulfillment. The Lord's Supper is not a casual ritual but a divinely instituted means of communion with the risen Christ. Faithful administration requires adherence to Christ's pattern, elements, and meaning. When rightly observed, the Supper proclaims Christ's death, affirms covenant identity, and mediates spiritual nourishment to the Church. Deviations from its institution constitute not mere liturgical variation but theological error and dishonor the Lord of the table.